



GOD'S CHOSEN ONE

For millions of Christians across the country, the canonisation of Sister Alphonsa was a rare occasion for celebrations, coming at a time when the community is under attack from a fringe of the majority

■ By M.G. Radhakrishnan

The irony was not lost on anyone, certainly not on Pope Benedict XVI, or the 5,000 attendees from Kerala, frantically waving the tricolour in St. Peter's Square last week. The celebration over the canonisation of a nun from the state was somewhat sobered by the knowledge that in India, another nun, was the cause of national shame after she was raped during the anti-Christian atrocities in Orissa. The pontiff made mention of the incidents during the service which elevated Sister Alphonsa, a nun from Kottayam who died in 1946, to the status of a saint. The Pope's mention was a sign of the concern in the international community over the issue but thankfully it was overshadowed by the celebrations in Rome and Kerala over the nun who is now officially Saint Alphonsa.

Indeed, October 12 will go down as a historic day in the 2,000-year-old history of India's 24 million-strong Christian community and the Roman Catholics who constitute 70 per cent of it, in particular. The canonisation of the first Indian woman as a saint by the Vatican, headquarters of the Catholic Church representing the world's two billion Catholics, one-sixth of the world population, is a unique honour and one that is earned by the strictest of verifications and in extraordinary circumstances.

Many argue that St. Alphonsa, as she will be called now, is the first "full-fledged" Indian saint after the other Indian with that title, Gonzalo Garcia, the 16th century priest who had a Portuguese father. When Benedict XVI declared Alphonsa (1910-1946) a saint among three others at the elaborate ceremony in St. Peter's Square, around 7,000 archbishops, priests, nuns, political leaders, devotees and, irony of ironies, a minister specially deputed by the state's Left Democratic Front Government, were also present at the function. Kerala itself exploded with festivities as thousands converged on the Alphonsa Chapel which houses her tomb



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in the 1,000-year-old St. Mary's Forane church at Bharananganam, a top pilgrim attraction today. The Franciscan Clarist nun belonged to the Syro-Malabar Church (SMC), India's largest and richest Catholic denomination. The SMC, one of the world's 21 oriental Catholic churches, runs educational institutions and hospitals and is said to have been founded in 52 A.D. by St. Thomas, one of Christ's 12 apostles.

At the Franciscan Clarist Congregation (FCC) convent in Bharananganam near

INDIA SHINING: Over 5,000 attendees waved the tricolour as they greeted Pope Benedict XVI